Rehabilitation. The commissioner of police became the president and Kiran the founder general secretary. (Kiran continues to remain so till date.)

The Navjyoti centre soon became popular and, with the large amount of community assistance that the programme was receiving, five more such centres were developed within a year. Of the nineteen police stations under her charge, six were running drug abuse treatment centres. Although each centre was primarily meant for thirty patients, the programme was so popular and so essential that, at times, one centre had to cater to a hundred patients at a time.

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The Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act came into force in 1986. Section 27 of the Act provides that one does not have to be shown to be in possession of drugs but has merely to be an admitted abuser, or have complaints lodged against him about his abuse, or be proved medically to be an abuser, to come under the purview of the Act. Such a person, if he volunteers for medical treatment, may be legally referred to treatment centres. It is only under Section 21 of the Act, where one has to be shown to be actually in possession of drugs of specified quantity notified under the law, that criminal proceedings are initiated. Navjyoti was a registered voluntary organization and those booked under Section 27 of the NDPS Act were sent there.

In December 1994, an arrest in which she was involved in 1987, while she was DCP (N), made news in the dailies. She had nabbed two people with 90 kg of charas (hashish made from the cannabis plant) in their possession. The case was presented in the Sessions Court and the sessions judge was satisfied with the investigation and the presentation of evidence and convicted the duo. After that, the two accused appealed to the Delhi High Court. In December 1994 they were acquitted and the judge strongly indicted the arresting officer Kiran Bedi in words she believes are unwarrantedly derogatory and also almost defamatory.

The NDPS Act provides for the presence of a gazetted officer, besides the arresting officer, at the time of an arrest under the Act. A newspaper file picture showed the duo being arrested by Kiran Bedi along with subordinate members of her staff. There was no sign of any other gazetted officer in the picture. This technicality was taken by the Delhi High Court judge to be sufficient to warrant an acquittal. And in the order the honourable judge indicted Kiran for being a ‘press-hungry’ officer.

Kiran retorts indignantly: ‘This was certainly not warranted. Whenever there is a major operation by the police the press calls us up at odd hours to confirm the story. So, instead of waiting to answer these inevitably forthcoming calls, I released a press statement. That does not make one press hungry. And, if this technicality about the photograph could warrant such derogatory comments for me, then what about the sessions judge who convicted the two? And what about all the press conferences that senior police officers hold from time to time and instantly on any important arrest? Are they all publicity hungry, or are they performing a duty of informing the people? What is to my mind important is what should I reveal without compromising the interrogation. The display of seizures by the Income Tax Department, Customs, Narcotics and Police is usual. What was unusual in my case?’

That Kiran is press hungry and wants to be in the limelight are oft-repeated charges against her. In 1989, while she was the deputy director of the Narcotics Control Bureau, she was part of the NCB team that swooped down on the verdant hills of what was then western Uttar Pradesh (now Uttarakhand), in the Chakrata and Tuni *tehsils* of Dehradun district. Poppy was being cultivated extensively in the area by naïve agriculturists who were being compelled to do so by big landlords with powerful political connections. Members of the press also accompanied the NCB team. This team was split into two, with one group going up to Chakrata and the other moving further ahead to